

EXECUTIVE PROPOSAL

Give Every Ain Founder an EIR Between Meetings

A stage-gated proposal for persistent, 24/7, human-led AI venture coaching



~120 venture-scale opportunity	7 EIR profiles currently listed [S3]	1 governed capstone persona first
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Project sponsor	Professor Roberto Colangelo, Executive Director, Ain Center for Entrepreneurship and Innovation
Audience	Professor Roberto Colangelo, Ain Center leadership, University decision-makers, and prospective program sponsors
Date	September 2026

Working name: Ain Foundry Virtual Entrepreneur-in-Residence (vEIR). This document proposes a human-led, AI-amplified capability; it does not authorize deployment or the use of any person's likeness.

EXECUTIVE BRIEF

1. Decision requested

Authorize a stage-gated capstone prototype

Approve discovery, institutional review, and a one-EIR / 8-12-venture prototype designed to prove persistent coaching, evidence quality, confidentiality, and human escalation before any program-wide commitment.

Why this matters now

The Ain Center exists to help University of Rochester students, faculty, and staff turn ideas into commercializable ventures. Its portfolio spans everyday student concepts through research-intensive biomedical and technical commercialization. The sponsor briefing identified the central operating constraint: approximately 120 ventures can require guidance from a small group of experienced EIRs whose time is both valuable and scarce. [S1] The University reported 116 business concepts in the Ain Foundry during the last academic year, validating the scale. [S2]

~17 ventures per listed EIR profile if evenly distributed	Always on practice and routine diagnosis	Escalate judgment-intensive and high-risk matters
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The proposed answer

Assign each venture a persistent virtual Entrepreneur-in-Residence: a clearly disclosed AI avatar grounded in the Ain method, the approved expertise and coaching style of a consenting EIR, and the venture's own private, correctable memory. It challenges founders, teaches frameworks, rehearses high-stakes conversations, tracks evidence and milestones, and prepares better human handoffs.

What approval does - and does not - mean

Approval authorizes Requirements discovery, consent and vendor diligence, safe-data prototyping, one governed persona, a small founder cohort, and evidence-based evaluation.	Approval does not authorize Program-wide deployment, unrestricted venture or lab data, public use of an EIR likeness, autonomous professional advice, or external commitments by the AI.
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SEVEN LISTED PROFILES; AVAILABILITY TO CONFIRM

1A. The EIR portfolio already spans distinct venture needs

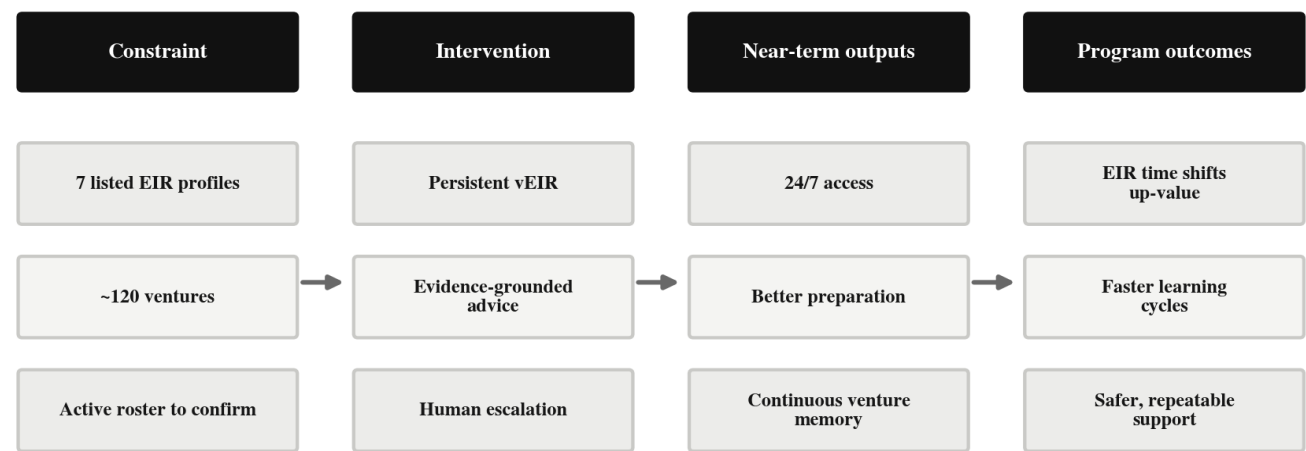
The official Ain directory currently lists seven EIR profiles whose public backgrounds span growth, leadership, finance, operations, global strategy, science commercialization, and clinical program building. That breadth strengthens the product case for expertise-aware routing, but the public list must not be treated as proof of active Foundry capacity or permission to create a persona. [S3]

Listed EIR	Public focus	High-value human moments
John Schloff	Growth, marketing leadership, product management, emerging technology	Go-to-market design; customer process; product portfolio; traditional-market entry
David Mammano	Entrepreneurship, leadership, education, motivation	Founder leadership; narrative; workshop-style coaching; resilience and communication
Kate Washington	Finance, operations, economic development, global growth	Operating model; financial discipline; public-private partnerships; international expansion
Roberto Colangelo	Strategy, entrepreneurship, global marketing, biotech, energy	Venture strategy; commercialization; emerging markets; fundraising and government modernization
Scott Walker	Finance, operations, capital projects, sales and investor relations	Startup finance; operating cadence; capital planning; sales execution; investor readiness
Dina Uzri	Science-to-market commercialization, biotech, product and business development	Research translation; value proposition; life-science pathway; fundraising and strategic planning
Truptesh H. Kothari	Clinical program building, health-system operations, multidisciplinary growth	Clinical innovation; healthcare delivery; stakeholder alignment; quality and scalable programs

Leadership action
Confirm the active roster, each EIR's availability and venture remit, and one willing capstone participant. Only then set capacity assumptions, assignment logic, likeness capture, or program-wide economics.

SCALE WITHOUT DILUTION

2. The operating opportunity



Human EIRs remain accountable for consequential guidance and program decisions.

Figure 1. The vEIR converts a scarce-advisor constraint into continuous preparation and better-directed human attention.

The bottleneck is continuity, not entrepreneurship content

Generic tools can explain standard venture phases. Professor Colangelo's project brief identifies the missing element as the nuance of a real venture being built over time: what the team has tried, learned, decided, promised, and still does not know. [S1] That is why persistence is the core product requirement.

Today	With a governed vEIR	Human EIR advantage
Founders wait or restart context at the next meeting.	The venture workspace remembers approved facts, decisions, experiments, and open questions.	Meetings begin at the decision, not at reconstruction.
Routine framework questions compete with strategic judgment.	The vEIR teaches, challenges, and prepares at any hour with evidence and uncertainty.	EIR time shifts to exceptions and consequential choices.
Referrals can depend on who knows the program landscape.	The system maps needs to Ain, UR, specialist, competition, regulator, funder, or incubator pathways.	Humans validate fit and make relationship-bearing introductions.
Portfolio needs are difficult to see without reading private details.	Approved aggregates show common blocks and escalation demand without pooling raw venture content.	Program design improves while confidentiality remains intact.

Strategic test
The system is valuable only if it creates higher-quality founder decisions and better human EIR interactions. Conversation volume and avatar realism are not success metrics.

A VENTURE-BUILDING OPERATING SYSTEM

3. The founder experience

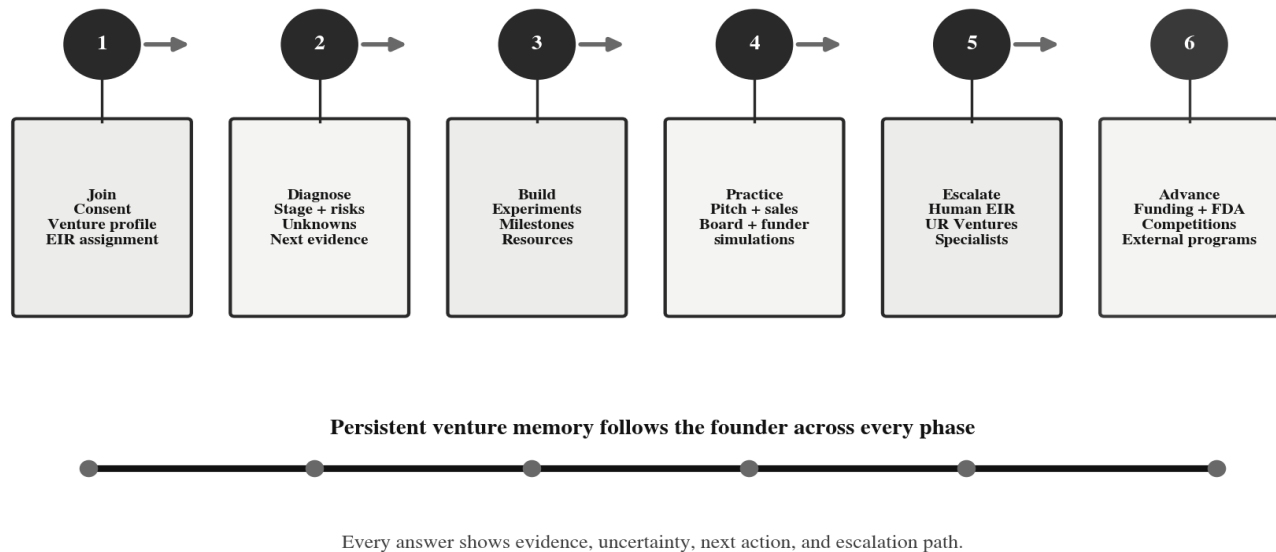


Figure 2. One persistent vEIR supports the venture from diagnosis to the right next ecosystem.

What a founder experiences

1. The founder signs in, sees the synthetic disclosure, and enters an isolated venture workspace.
2. The vEIR knows approved venture history and asks the hardest current question instead of restarting from zero.
3. Advice separates facts, assumptions, hypotheses, and recommendations; evidence and uncertainty are visible.
4. The founder rehearses a customer, investor, board, partner, or pitch interaction and receives an evidence-focused critique.
5. The session closes with a diagnosis, challenge, next actions, memory updates, and any required human escalation.
6. When a human EIR or specialist is needed, the founder approves a concise context packet and tracks the handoff.

The system should feel like the EIR - without pretending to be the EIR

The intended fidelity includes approved expertise, judgment patterns, questioning style, directness, tone, accent, voice, and visual likeness. Those elements are technically and legally separable. Each requires explicit consent, bounded use, evaluation, disclosure, and revocation. The human EIR approves what professional alignment means; the system never claims that the EIR is live or personally endorsed a generated answer.

EXTERNAL SIGNAL, LOCAL DIFFERENTIATION

4. Why Ain can lead

HBS Foundry provides a visible market signal: its public eight-week startup bootcamp is powered by an AI platform, and reporting identifies HeyGen-built faculty avatars used to provide feedback in practice interactions. [S9][S10] Ain should not copy the format. It can build a more institutionally embedded and longitudinal capability around the problem its sponsor already defined.

Market signal	Ain opportunity
Founders will engage with AI-supported venture-building workflows and instructor avatars.	Place the capability inside a trusted, local EIR and program relationship rather than a generic standalone assistant.
Practice simulations can extend learning beyond live sessions.	Add persistent venture memory so diagnosis and preparation improve across the venture lifecycle.
AI can make high-quality entrepreneurial support more accessible.	Connect advice to Ain, UR Ventures, medical, research, competition, mentor, funding, and regional pathways.
Synthetic faculty identities attract attention and risk.	Lead with explicit consent, continuous disclosure, human authority, venture isolation, and measurable quality.

Defensible Ain assets

- Longitudinal venture operating memory with visible sources, corrections, and decisions.
- EIR-approved doctrine and scenario evaluation, not just a face and voice.
- Ain's resource and referral graph across disciplines and commercialization pathways.
- Human handoff workflows that turn AI preparation into real relationships and judgment.
- Governed cross-venture learning from reviewed, de-identified patterns rather than raw data pooling.

Recommended technology position

Own the conversational brain, venture memory, evidence, policies, and evaluation. Use a replaceable provider for real-time visual embodiment. HeyGen documents an Avatar Only mode for bringing a custom conversational stack, while Azure supports real-time avatar synthesis but applies limited-access and consent requirements to custom voice and avatars. [S5][S6][S7][S8]

STAGE-GATED EXECUTION

5. Capstone prototype and pilot

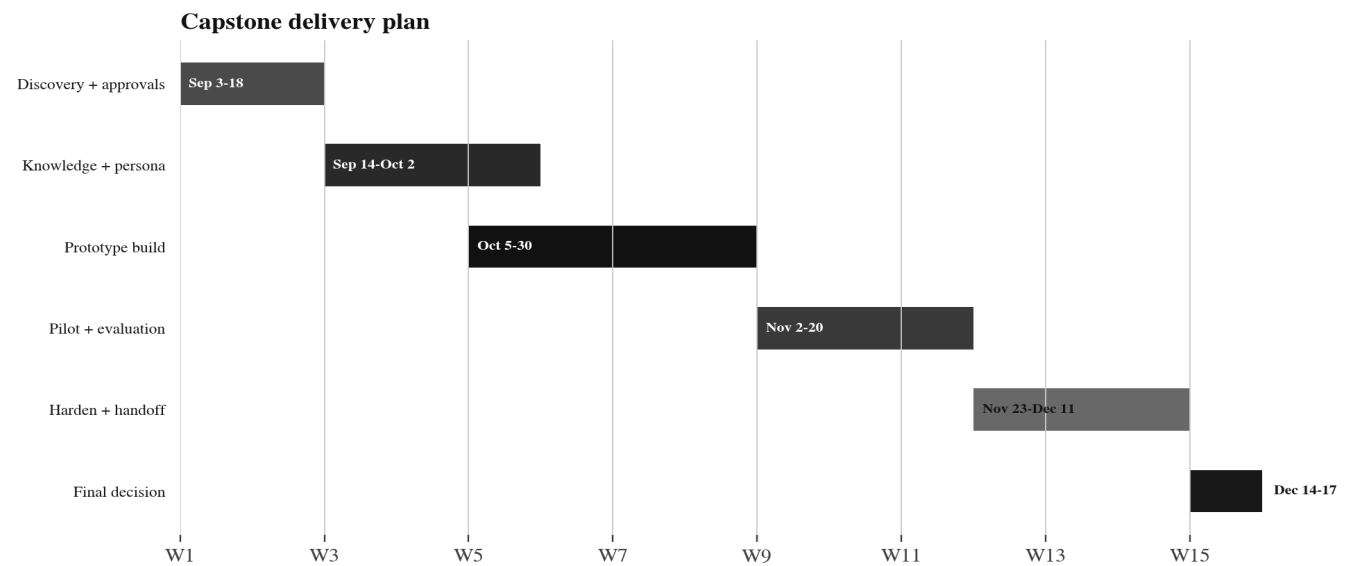


Figure 3. Proposed capstone delivery plan through December 17, 2026, subject to the official course calendar and approval timing.

Phase	What is produced	Gate
1 - Discover and approve	Charter, founder and EIR interviews, consent path, data inventory, vendor and institutional review.	Safe prototype boundary and named owners.
2 - Build knowledge and persona	EIR doctrine, style card, approved corpus, gold scenarios, and representative avatar spike.	EIR approves the evaluation standard and intended use.
3 - Build V1	Authenticated venture workspaces, persistent memory, evidence, challenge / coaching modes, escalation, and avatar adapter.	Core end-to-end founder journey works.
4 - Evaluate	8-12 ventures, three or more sessions each, blind EIR scoring, usability, latency, and 100+ privacy tests.	Safety gates pass; quality and utility meet pilot targets.
5 - Handoff	Technical package, operating blueprint, evaluation report, cost model, risk register, and 90-day pilot plan.	Leadership chooses proceed, revise, or stop.

Proposed success gates

0	>=4/5	>=90%	>=95%
critical cross-venture disclosures	median EIR advisory-quality score	approved venture-fact recall	high-risk escalation recall

Targets are proposed for the capstone and must be finalized during discovery. A failed safety gate blocks deployment regardless of aggregate satisfaction.

TRUST IS THE PRODUCT

6. Governance and risk controls

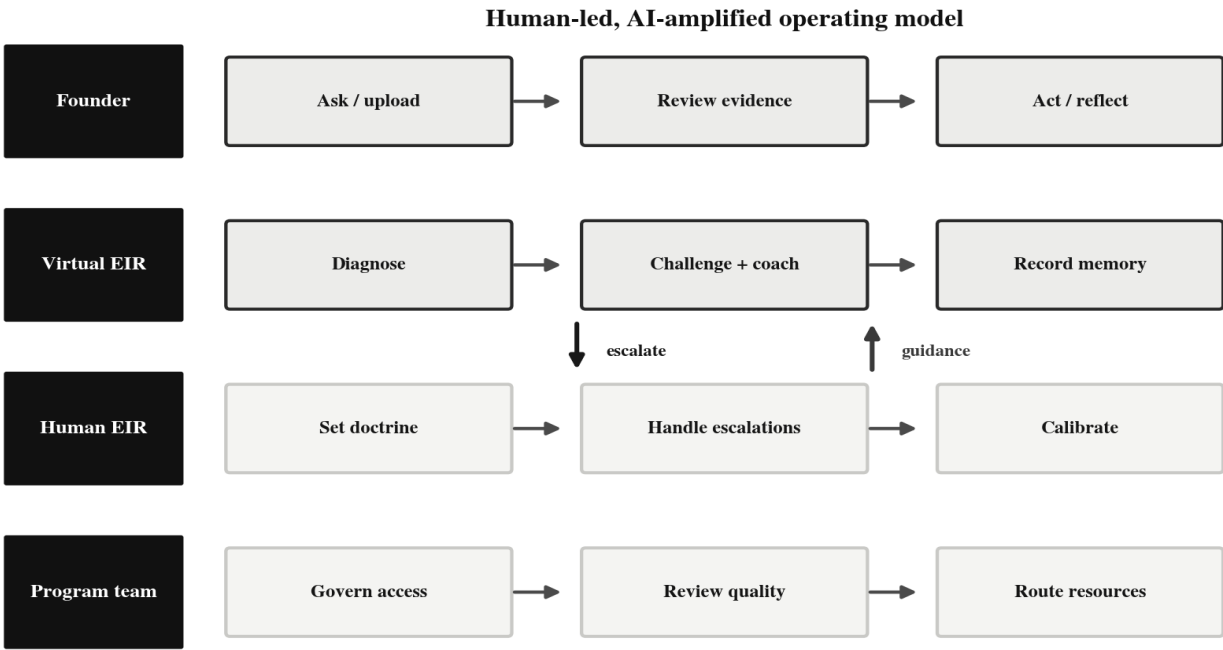


Figure 4. Human EIRs and Ain operators remain accountable; the vEIR handles bounded, reviewable work.

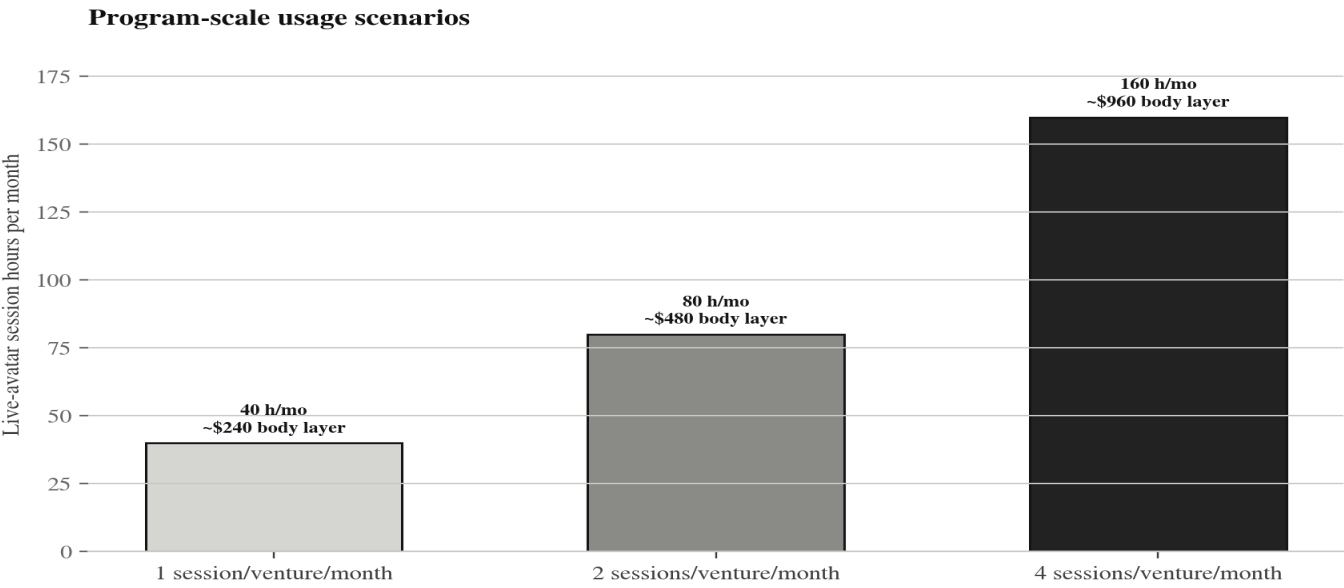
Risk	Control commitment
Deceptive identity or over-trust	Persistent synthetic disclosure; no claim that the EIR is live or personally approved an answer; clear report and feedback path.
Likeness and voice misuse	Explicit written and recorded consent as applicable; approved audiences and uses; protected assets; suspension, revocation, and retirement.
Cross-venture confidentiality	Venture-scoped authorization and row-level controls; no raw cross-venture retrieval; red-team testing across data, logs, exports, and support paths.
Bad or stale advice	Source-linked claims, visible uncertainty, freshness metadata, EIR evaluation, correction, and human escalation.
Professional / regulated decisions	Education and preparation only; mandatory escalation for IP, legal, medical, regulatory, securities, safety, and other high-risk matters.
Institutional data exposure	Begin with public, synthetic, or expressly authorized low-risk data; expand only after University classification and approval. [S11][S12][S13]
Vendor lock-in	Provider adapter; Ain retains the doctrine, memory, policies, tests, consent record, and exit / deletion evidence.
Unfunded operating burden	Named product owner, EIR calibration cadence, incident process, source owners, review queue, cost dashboard, and stage gates.

Governance principle

The project should align to NIST's lifecycle approach to governing, mapping, measuring, and managing generative-AI risk, while applying University-specific data, research, privacy, procurement, security, and accessibility requirements. [S14]

MEASURED EXPANSION

7. Economics and scale path



Illustrative: 120 ventures, 20-minute sessions, and \$0.10/min Avatar Only rate. Excludes LLM, ASR, TTS, storage, support, and implementation.

Figure 5. Illustrative body-layer usage only. At 120 ventures and 20-minute sessions, monthly live-avatar demand ranges from 40 to 160 hours across one to four sessions per venture. [S7][S8]

Investment logic

- The first investment buys evidence: a safe-data prototype, one governed persona, a founder cohort, institutional diligence, and a reusable technical and operating design.
- Production cost scales mainly with avatar minutes, speech, model / retrieval use, storage and security, vendor support, and people needed for persona and program operations.
- The business case should compare cost per qualified venture-progress event and improvement in human EIR preparation - not AI minutes against a human salary.
- No fixed program budget should be approved before measuring real session duration, frequency, concurrency, fallback use, support load, and EIR calibration time.

Three-stage scale path

Stage	Scope	Leadership decision
Capstone	1 persona; 8-12 ventures; safe / authorized data; limited duration.	Does the core system deserve a real operational pilot?
Controlled pilot	2 personas; about 30 ventures; formal owner, support, and review cadence.	Does it create founder value and human EIR leverage at acceptable risk and cost?
Foundry scale	Active EIR network; approximately 120 ventures; production governance and accessibility.	Should Ain operate this as program infrastructure and potentially extend it across the University?

DECISION PACKAGE

8. Leadership commitments and next actions

Approvals requested now

- 1. Confirm Professor Roberto Colangelo as project sponsor and designate the Ain operational owner for requirements, founder recruitment, and escalation routing.
- 2. Authorize interviews with EIRs, operators, and a small set of founders, subject to any required research or program-review determination.
- 3. Nominate one EIR for the first persona and begin a formal consent, intended-use, and vendor-feasibility process; use a neutral surrogate body until approval is complete.
- 4. Authorize University security, privacy, accessibility, procurement, data, research, and contract stakeholders to review the proposed boundary and candidate vendors.
- 5. Approve a capstone pilot target of 8-12 ventures only after the data and consent gates pass.
- 6. Commit to a December proceed / revise / stop review based on the agreed quality, privacy, utility, latency, and human-leverage evidence.

Immediate 30-day actions

Week	Action	Output
1	Sponsor working session; name owners; confirm scale and first founder jobs.	Signed-off charter and decision log.
1-2	EIR and founder discovery; data classification; consent and institutional-review routing.	Requirements, journey, risk and data maps.
2	HeyGen Avatar Only and Azure feasibility spikes using synthetic content.	Measured latency, quality, access, cost, and vendor constraints.
2-3	Curate EIR doctrine and 30-50 gold scenarios; define escalation matrix.	Persona card and evaluation benchmark.
3-4	Build authenticated venture memory, retrieval, evidence, and text-first orchestration.	Core prototype independent of the body provider.
4	Integrate the approved embodiment path and run the first full regression suite.	Pilot-candidate V1 and gate review.

Recommended leadership position

Proceed with a bounded capstone prototype. Preserve ambition - real-time, EIR-specific, emotionally and stylistically faithful interaction - while making persistence, evidence, confidentiality, consent, and human authority the first release gates.

DECISION BASIS

9. Evidence register

Evidence class	How leadership should use it	Important limit
Sponsor and Ain evidence	Defines the problem, desired behaviors, operating context, and current planning baseline.	Reconfirm the authoritative active-EIR count before capacity and contracting decisions.
Vendor documentation	Establishes current capabilities, integration patterns, consent gates, and public pricing inputs.	Availability, contract terms, retention, and production limits require written validation.
External benchmark	Shows that AI-mediated venture education is moving into credible institutions.	It is an analogy, not proof that the Ain design will work.
University and NIST guidance	Frames data classification, approved-tool review, and lifecycle AI risk management.	The project still needs institution-specific determinations and named owners.

Selected sources

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